Renovation

By Naomi Shihab Nye

INTRODUCTION

Put together one very run-down house, a deserving family, several opinionated designers, seven days and what do you get? The answer is Extreme Makeover: Home Edition. The lives of the lucky families are forever changed when they learn that they've been selected to have their home walls moved, their floors replaced and even their facades radically changed. And America has been consumed with the need to watch the events unfold for the last 6 years! When Naomi Shihab Nye faces her own minor home improvement project, the built in frustrations become more than just a personal challenge . . . they become a reason to reflect on the situations of families in her home country of Palestine. It truly takes reflections on those less fortunate than our selves to make us appreciate what we do have. Renovation by Naomi Shihab Nye.

It cheered me that the man and woman ripping our house apart were a married couple. Maybe this meant they would be more careful with things. Delia neatly packed all the belongings from the rooms where mold was detected in large cardboard boxes marked KITCHEN

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ITEMS and BATH – the mugs, spatulas, pots and pans, towels, bottles of shampoo. Chico draped large sheets of plastic from the 13-foot high ceilings for "containment." Then they both donned plastic space suits and face masks and began smashing the hundred year old green and white tile of the kitchen counter and the blue Mexican bird tile in the bathroom to take it out. The mold was under wood and sheet rock. It likes to eat adhesive. A very subversive guest. Goodbye familiar cracks and rounded edges. Goodbye heavy wooden drawers and stained porcelain bathtub. Our neighbors looked scared when they saw the spacemen in the yard. We moved out for five weeks.

Old is not a very glamorous topic, but it could be growing inside anybody's walls at any moment, finding its own safe harbor of moist secrecy, spreading and thickening in green or black creepy glory. You could have it too. We had mostly green but a little black. It gave me asthma even before it started sneaking out of a hole in the ceiling over the bathtub. Thanks to a leak in the

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roof and two other unrelated leaks in two wall-pipes we had it. Our hundred-year-old cottage was sabotaged. But considering all the possibilities for leakage in this world, it amazes me that more things don't leak. It amazes me that poop goes into the poop pipe and relatively clean water comes out of the faucet. It all amazes me. I know some people who have had to bulldoze their entire houses and throw away all their belongings thanks to mold. Delia called me into the front yard to see the boards from our bathroom wrapped in plastic. She pointed. There, there it is. See those little black and green spots? It is going away now. We are hauling it to the DUMP. You won't have it any more.

So we moved back into our house without any running water or toilets, it was like camping out at home. We ate peaches and icy cherry tomatoes from a big bowl. We drank coffee and made rum drinks in the afternoons, trying to replicate the happy hour at the hotel down the street, but it did not feel as fun. We drove around in

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the summer heat through traffic to gaze at tile and bathroom fixtures in too many stores and talked to carpenters and lighting experts and tried to make decisions. There are some people in the world who are good at doing this. We are not among them.

And then we waited. Fore someone to come measure. Fore substances to arrive from different directions. For things not to be broken. For them to be re-ordered. For someone to be able to put them in. Renovation involves mostly waiting. For the electrician who knows you cannot deal with those wires yourself. For the evangelical electrician's helper who looks uncannily like my gynecologist. For the diverter switch to arrive at a plumbing warehouse. For windows. For the counter installers who asked, how do you make a rose bush have more roses? What does it want and need? We started receiving mysterious catalogues like "Rest Room World." During all this, the Palestinians overseas were being confined to their homes, if they had homes, or to their shacks, rooms, tents, and hovels. They could not go out to buy fresh oranges. They could not go to school.

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More houses were being seized and demolished daily. The word "demolished" sounds softer than it is. But in the documentary movie "Gaza Strip" you can hear the terrifying crashing sounds of giant bulldozers as they knock down houses a hundred years old. One gets tired of saying or hearing the words but it keeps happening. The whole time we were putting our house back together, more Palestinians were losing their homes. They saw their fathers blindfolded, hauled off to prison in buses. They saw their friends gassed by poison, blown up, intestines strewn in the dust. Their mothers wailing and bloody. Why is this almost never considered news? Sometimes where everything comes from is just as critical as where everything in going.

I hate this, said the teenager we live with, one rare night when I asked him to help me wash and rinse dishes in a pan in the yard. We had had company for dinner. It was fun to have company with no running water or bathroom. They were a little taken aback. I poured water over their hands from a pitcher. They tried not

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to look at all the boxes piled up in the dining room. The teenager scraping plates said, how long is this going to go on? Don't some people get their whole houses rebuilt in, like, a week? Why is it taking so long for this to be completed?

Just think, I said to him. (This is never a good idea to say to a teen person, but I said it anyway.) Just consider someone coming and taking our house away, while we're in the middle of fixing things, while everything is a mess. How would you feel? They would say your room is their room. Your computer is now their computer. Or they would blow up your room and say, Ah, too bad, we call it security, no one cares if you suffer.

What are you talking about? he said. I'd call the police! What if you had no phone lines? What if the police had no power?
Stop talking like this. The mosquitoes are killing me. I hate washing dishes.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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